Chapter 6
Philosophical Issues in Hellenistic Astrology

Hellenistic astrology was developed and practiced during a very diverse period in which a number of different philosophical and religious schools flourished. A full treatment of the many ways in which these different schools interacted with or incorporated astrology into their approaches is beyond the scope of this book.[1] Instead I will highlight some specific philosophical issues and debates that became relevant to astrologers during the Greco-Roman period, since many of these issues continue to be relevant to astrologers today. I will begin by looking at the nature of divination before looking at issues such as fate and causality.

Astrology, Divination, and Signs

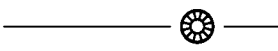
In the earlier Mesopotamian tradition, astrology was originally conceptualized as a form of divination. In fact, astrology was just one of many different forms of divination in the ancient world. Broadly speaking, divination is the interpretation of natural phenomena as conveying symbolically significant information about events in the past, present, or future. Typically, it is understood as the attempt to ascertain information from the divine, and especially to predict the future, by analyzing the arrangement of randomly determined objects at the moment of the inquiry.[2]

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[1] For an excellent overview see Lawrence, "Hellenistic Astrology."

[2] Hankinson paraphrases Cicero (*On Divination*, 2: 13–15; 26) in saying that "the Stoics defined divination as the foretelling of events that come about by chance." Hankinson, "Stoicism, Science and Divination," p. 153. In the same article he quotes Sextus Empiricus (*Against the Physicists*, 1: 132) as defining divination as "the science which observes and

Chapter 9
Configurations



> *Nor is it enough to know the special shapes of the signs and the individual ordinances which the stars impose on men at their birth; they also affect our destinies through their agreements with each other, for they rejoice in alliances and cooperate with one another according to their natures and locations.*[1]
>
> – Manilius

The third area of chart interpretation is known as the doctrine of configurations, which is more commonly referred to in modern astrology as the concept of "aspects." The primary purpose of configurations is that they allow the planets to form relationships and to interact with each other in different ways in the chart.

Reconstructing the Aspect Doctrine

While a number of astrological manuals survive from the Hellenistic tradition, they often take for granted that the reader is already familiar with a number of basic technical concepts, and they seldom define their terminology. This becomes the most problematic when dealing with the Hellenistic aspect doctrine, because many of the terms used for different types of configurations, as well as some of the underlying concepts, can be quite complex.

Sometime in the early Hellenistic tradition, an astrologer named Antiochus wrote a book in which he systematically defined most of the basic technical concepts. For this reason, Antiochus is a key source for reconstructing the Hellenistic doctrine of configurations, and his work appears to have influenced

[1] Manilius, *Astronomica*, 2: 270–2, trans. Goold, p. 105.

Church. This clearly matches one of the significations that Valens gives for Jupiter, which signifies "heads of holy places."[20]

Another example is William Rehnquist, who had Sagittarius rising, with Jupiter in Sagittarius in the first place in a day chart. He was an American lawyer, jurist, and political figure who served as an Associate Justice of the Supreme Court of the United States, and later became the sixteenth Chief Justice. He was the head of the Supreme Court for about nineteen years, which is the highest court in the United States. According to Valens, Jupiter also signifies "justice, authorities, governments, honors [...] and the arbitration of trials."[21]

Moving on to other planets, the American poet T. S. Eliot was born with Libra rising and Venus ruling the Hour-Marker, copresent with Mercury in the first place. In this instance, the combination of Venus and Mercury results in poetry, or aesthetically pleasing speech. The favorable placement of Venus in its own domicile indicated that he would excel in the arts; he won the Nobel Prize for Literature in 1948 for his pioneering contributions to contemporary poetry.

Filmmaker George Lucas was born with Taurus rising and Venus ruling the Hour-Marker in the first

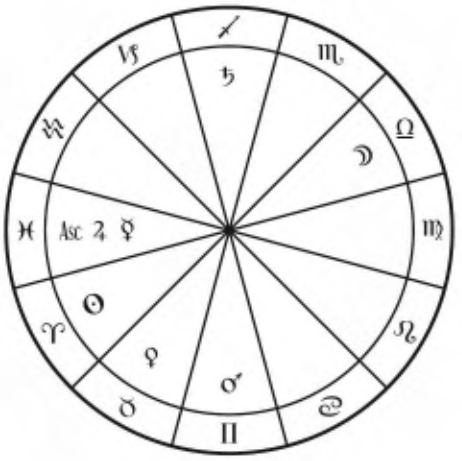


Chart 10 - Pope Benedict XVI

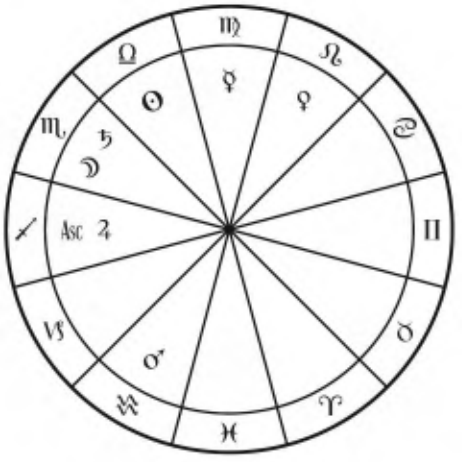


Chart 11 - William Rehnquist

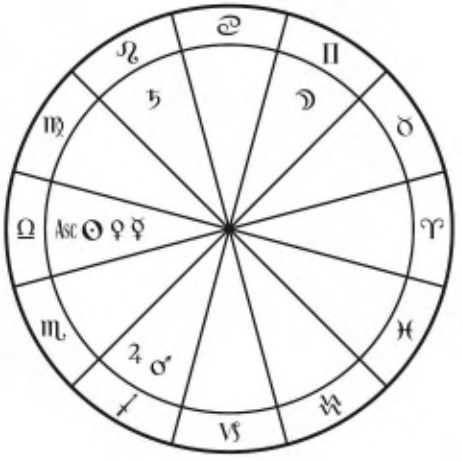


Chart 12 - T. S. Eliot

[20] Valens, *Anthology*, 1, 1: 17.
[21] Valens, *Anthology*, 1, 1: 17.